Building Digital Archives with Curation-Research-Driven Approaches

Franken, Lina
lina.franken@uni-vechta.de
University of Vechta, Germany

Mollenhauer, Sabina
sabina.mollenhauer@uni-vechta.de
University of Vechta, Germany

Sunder-Plaßmann, Lucia
lucia.sunder-plassmann@uni-vechta.de
University of Vechta, Germany

Introduction: Combining Approaches

In curating datasets, the focus within digital humanities still is on archival perspectives. We instead suggest to combine curation with research-driven approaches, taking into account research questions that are answered with the data digitized and indexed. This is showcased with a research project on everyday culture surrounding community function halls with restaurants, being central establishments for rural communities in past and present times.

The project curates research data. It links five heterogeneous collections revealing their complexity through the contexts that connect individual datasets. A research-driven approach combines this digitization and indexing with the collection and analysis of the underlying meanings and perspectives of the actors as supplementary information through ethnographic methods (Faubion / Marcus 2009). Enriched with this knowledge as metadata, the datasets become open data with the corresponding contextual findings.

The incorporation of ethnographic research-driven contextualization with innovative digital technologies of recording, modeling, archiving, and presenting such multi-faceted phenomena aims to adequately convey cultural-historical and contemporary complexity. Qualitative approaches can therefore be used to support the various interconnections as well as disparities.

Methodology

Research-driven approaches have been distinguished from curation-driven approaches to digital collections in their aims and thus their digital output (Flanders / Jannidis 2015: 233). The curation-research-driven approach combines both, since contextual meaning of the archival material needs to be grasped: Instead of a pure curation of existing metadata, these are ethnographically enhanced and integrated into corresponding current scientific interpretations (Franken 2016). The resulting dataset answers specific research questions – in this case about the significance and role halls play in the transformation of rural areas – and opens up curated collections for subsequent use.

A wide range of objects is important, ranging from tableware to furniture, barware or decoration. Documents provide context that makes organizational structures and formats comprehensible. Existing photographic collections capture past events. This process-produced data is supplemented by research-induced data (Franken 2023: 66), which documents the current conditions and practices in photos and field notes. Qualitative narrative interviews with owners, regular guests and association members make the past activities on site comprehensible. Only through these contexts can the significance of the data be understood.

The indexing includes the respective provenance, according to current standards (LIDO, Coburn et al. 2010). The corresponding controlled vocabularies used (WortnetzKultur, Spree / Lindenthal / Knaack 2012) are enriched to better cover everyday culture. The data generated is stored in a university repository and accessible via repositories such as Europeana (Petras et al. 2017). The digital asset management system (DAM) integrates the IIIF-API standard for the delivery of image data. Thematic contextual information is structured into an exhibition to be presented both on site and online.

As a result, process-produced archival material is combined with research-induced material explicitly collected for the research. Methodologically and analytically, it is not only the digital linking of heterogeneous source data that needs to be processed, but also the working out of differences and similarities between existing retro-digitized material and digitally collected data for research purposes.

Results: Archiving Intangible Cultural Heritage Through its Material Heritage

Multifaceted everyday life consisted and consists to a large extent of intangible cultural heritage, which is in many regards metacultural (Tauschek 2011) and difficult to make accessible via individual digital representations (Noll 2022). Transformations of practices and their meanings over time need to be graspable in a combination of multimodal data. Rural customs and festive culture, for example, can only be understood with photos from the event location if they are combined with stories about festivities, occasions, practices and locations. If objects from the institution in question and their usage are included, the complexity and multi-layered practices become tangible thanks to digital representations. Instead of being geared towards completeness, curation-research-driven approaches are guided by the research question for selection and context-oriented curation.

The heterogeneous holdings yield meaningful insights, especially when examined with a research question. Methodology and the handling of different source material are interconnected following curation standards. Within this framework, individual community function halls with restaurants and their heterogeneous holdings will be processed as models. The combination of contextualizing interviews, ethnographic documentation, digitization and indexing enables the diversity to be combined and mapped digitally.

Interim Conclusion: Curation-Research-Driven Approaches as a Way of Contextualizing Digitized Material

Curation-research-driven approaches including ethnography is counteracting the fragmentation of data in order to reconstruct bodies of knowledge in their constructedness. We present curation-research-driven data practices in their making while contributing to the infrastructures and standardization efforts interwoven: Fragmented data is brought back together in its representation and presentation. The concept of curation-research-driven approaches will be showcased as realized within the project, including technical implementation, challenges and the potential for sustainable digital scientific practice and the model it can serve for others.

Bibliography

Coburn, Erin / Light, Richard / McKenna, Gordon / Stein, Regine / Vitzthum, Axel (2010): *LIDO. Lightweight Information Describing Objects Version 1.0*. http://www.lido-schema.org/schema/v1.0/lido-v1.0-specification.pdf.

Faubion, James D. / Marcus, George E. (2009): *Fieldwork is not What it Used to be. Learning Anthropology's Method in a Time of Transition*. Ithaca: Cornell Univ. Press.

Flanders, Julia / Jannidis, Fotis (2015): "Data Modeling", in: Schreibman, Susan / Siemens, Raymond George / Unsworth, John (eds.): *A New Companion to Digital Humanities*. Chichester u.a.: Wiley Blackwell 229–237.

Franken, Lina (2016): „Bericht. Kulturelles Erbe des Rheinlandes online entdecken", in: *Rheinisch-westfälische Zeitschrift für Volkskunde* 61: 289–290.

Franken, Lina (2023). *Digitale Methoden für qualitative Forschung. Computationelle Daten und Verfahren*. Münster/New York: UTB.

Noll, Marsina (2022): „ISGV-Bildarchiv revisited. Neue Zugänge - neue Fragestellungen", in: Kulbe, Nadine / Jacobs, Theresa / Keller, Ines / Knöhr, Nathalie / Noll, Marsina / Spieker, Ira (eds.): *Bildarchive. Wissensordnungen - Arbeitspraktiken – Nutzungspotenziale*. Dresden: Institut für Sächsische Geschichte und Volkskunde; Sächsische Landesbibliothek – Staats- und Universitätsbibliothek Dresden 218–226.

Petras, Vivien / Hill, Timothy / Stiller, Juliane / Gäde, Maria (2017): "Europeana. A Search Engine for Digitised Cultural Heritage Material", in: *Datenbank-Spektrum* 17/1, 41–46.

Spree, Ulrike / Lindenthal, Jutta / Knaack, Andje (2012): „Wortnetz Kultur – ein Thesaurusprojekt zur kollaborativen Erschließung von Fachinformationen des kulturellen Erbes", in: *Information. Wissenschaft & Praxis* 63 (1), 23–36.

Tauschek, Markus (2011): "Reflections on the Metacultural Nature of Intangible Cultural Heritage", in: *Journal of Ethnology and Folkloristics* 5/2, 49–64.